

A hard pill to swallow

Is it just me, or are we starting to miss out on some powerful leaders in the technology space? Not companies, I know Google and Apple own the world – for now. I mean strong and powerful people like Steve Jobs, or Bill Gates. Regardless of whether you loved or hated them, they seemed to be the people on a mission. They started their companies, and they had that sense of ownership, I suppose. I know stockholders actually own companies technically, but that's like saying Nike owns Manchester United because they might give them a rumoured billion pound sponsorship. Stockholders are like the men who bet on football. You always try and put your money on the winner, and yes, sometimes you lose, and abandon loyalties and move on to the next cash cow.

Companies, brands and even products are made great by passion and commitment. The reverse holds true also – some brands and products are horrible because of the confusion or a lack of vision by the spearhead(s). Not all companies are run this way, of course, but certainly the ones you remember are the ones that have a colourful character at the helm.

For Apple it was Steve Jobs, who came across as a no-nonsense go-getter in a single minded pursuit for perfection. For Microsoft it used to be Bill Gates, who came across as a business whizkid, making sure we were addicted to his software. It's people like these who seem to make you sit up and take notice, for better or worse, and think what you want about them, you still respect them for having a vision. These people also inspire fanboys. Not that that's a good thing in my opinion, because I hate fanboys, almost as much as I hate evangelists... but this isn't the time or place for *that* discussion.

What I'm building up to here is the fact that the PC race seems done and dusted. No they're not going anywhere just yet, so I'm not making one of those idiotic "the PC is dead" proclamations. What I'm saying is that the PC market is almost boring now, because you have a few players, they're all very well settled, you have your leaders and the ones playing catch up, but it's almost always been that way. And that's only the hardware side... on the software side it's pretty much Microsoft all the way.

The smartphone business has a little more excitement, but perhaps the problem of way too many players. It's the tablet market that seems to hold the key to success in portability.

However, in the West, it almost seems like game over – Apple's like Usain Bolt, already won even though the race is still being run, and the only way they can lose is to muck it up themselves.

And mucking it up is very much a possibility now, because they seem to lack someone to bring in all new fans. With the launch of the iPad mini, reactions range from "This is the best thing since sliced bread" to "Ho-hum", or the media favourite, "Would the iPad mini exist if Steve Jobs were still alive?"

We ask this because it was Jobs himself who criticised the smaller 7-inch screens of rivals, basically saying they were confused products that were too small to be tablets and too big to be smartphones. So of course Apple couldn't come out with a 7-inch version, so they came out with a 7.9-inch version. Apparently because the iPad is 9.7-inch so making the mini 7.9-inch makes it easy to remember. Or maybe it's just the good old "Only \$999 is a lot better than saying \$10" marketing gimmick. Either way, 7.something-inch is clearly taking on the other 7-inch tablets.

Reviews online range from "amazing" to "ho-hum" as well, and we'll reserve judgement for when we see it ourselves. One thing's pretty clear though, this is a repackaged iPad 2 with a smaller screen, and after making such a big deal about retina displays, the resolution is a little disappointing. Also the price is higher than the Nexus 7, and now people are comparing the two to one another. Apple has shown it's hand, and now Google has the chance to come back at it with something amazing. For the first time, we're seeing Apple taking on someone head to head. All this time it's been like a Bugatti Veyron against many Premier Padminis (Pad-mini, get it?), but by levelling the playing field to try and get into the 7-inch space, is Apple shooting itself in the foot?

Sometimes trying to capture markets you don't compete in isn't always the best way forward. What happens to Apple's image (without its iconic leader) when it competes and loses in a head-to-head battle? Losing in an apples to oranges comparison is one thing, but losing Apple to apple could really be bad for a market leader. Only time will tell. 



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